



BLOG POST

HOW THEATRE IS CHANGING THE CONVERSATION ON PLASTIC POLLUTION IN LAKE VICTORIA, KISUMU, KENYA.

Lake Victoria has sustained communities for generations, providing food, economic opportunities, improving livelihoods, and as a strong sense of identity. Every morning, fishermen head out onto its waters hoping for a good catch. Yet the lake is changing. Plastic waste and untreated effluent have found their way into the lake and the fisherfolk communities are confronting a worrying reality; the lake is no longer giving as it once did. Declining fish production has affected livelihoods, food security and the wellbeing of communities that depend on the lake. Moreover, understanding why this is happening is not always straightforward. For some communities, the explanation was not pollution or changing environmental conditions. It was something else entirely; a belief that the decline in fish was a punishment from God. These misconceptions limited community action in addressing the degradation of the lake's ecosystem. This is where **Amazon Theatrx Ensemble's 'Voice of Sango' initiative** found an unconventional entry point: The Stage.

The Solution

Rather than relying solely on conventional environmental awareness campaigns, 'Voice of Sango' brought artists together to develop spoken-word and theatre pieces around plastic pollution, waste management and the health of Lake Victoria. The artists were trained to translate complex messages into stories and performances that could resonate with communities. Interestingly, the performances were not only designed to deliver information but also to start conversations and spark reflections. Through community performances and interactive sessions, audiences were invited to reflect on how household waste is managed, where plastic ends up and how their everyday practices can contribute to pollution of Lake Victoria thereby affecting their health, their livelihoods, and their future.



Street Performance Engaging Communities On Plastic Pollution and Waste Management



Street Performance for Environmental Awareness

What worked

One of the most significant successes came after the performances ended. Community members stayed behind to talk, ask questions, reflect and sharing how their understanding had changed. Many admitted they had never linked plastic pollution and untreated waste with declining fish populations, believing instead that the changes were caused by fate or supernatural forces. Through these conversations, communities began recognising how their everyday actions contribute to environmental degradation and why protecting the lake also means protecting their health, food security and livelihoods. Climate and environmental challenges can feel distant and overwhelming when presented only through technical terminologies, statistics or scientific reports. But when communities can connect a changing environment to their own experiences and actions, the problem becomes tangible.

The experiences also came with an important reality check; limited resources. Like many community-based initiatives, the ambition of the work was greater than the funding available to support expansion of performances to more communities and training of additional local artists. This limited how far the performances and engagement activities could reach. However, this constraint also reinforced an important lesson: impactful climate-health communication does not always begin with expensive campaigns. It can begin with people, creativity, and participation. The initiative deliberately involved communities in the planning and execution of activities rather than treating them simply as recipients of information. Young people, women and people with disabilities were also identified as important voices in ensuring that the intervention did not leave underrepresented groups behind.

Lessons Worth 'Stealing'

1. Climate change is often addressed through policies, infrastructure projects and technological innovations and these investments are essential. But the experience of Amazon Theatrix Ensemble highlights another equally important lesson: lasting climate action begins when communities understand the problem and see themselves as part of the solution. Participatory approaches can make climate and health communication more relevant, understandable, and locally owned.
2. Effective communication does not require ignoring existing beliefs. It requires understanding them. The shift from seeing declining fish stocks as divine punishment to recognising the role of pollution demonstrates the importance of creating safe spaces where misconceptions can be explored rather than simply dismissed.
3. Inclusion is not an add-on. Young people, women and people with disabilities should not be treated as passive audiences. Their involvement in designing and implementing interventions can strengthen relevance, ownership, and reach.

The **'Voice of Sango'** experience raises a broader question for climate-health practitioners and policymakers: **Are we using every tool available to us to help communities understand climate and environmental risks?**

Case study: 'Voice of Sango' Initiative by Amazon Theatrix Ensemble. Shared as part of the CAPCHA case study collection by Edwin Koga.



Community members watching a theatre performance along Lake Victoria Shores